

Variants & shelved rules

Everything not in the base game, kept in one place

None of these are part of Blink. Some were in earlier versions and were retired; some were designed and simulated but never adopted. They are written out properly so that a decision can be revisited later without reconstructing it from memory.

Badges say how much is known: **RETIRED** was once a base rule · **SIMULATED** measured, never played · **UNTESTED** written only. Add one at a time, and only after the base game is familiar. The **Wasteland & Disaster** and **Trade** modules are larger and live in their own documents.

01 Pattern placement **RETIRED IN V0.21**

WHY IT WAS RETIRED, AND THE CASE FOR PUTTING IT BACK

It was cut for **simplification**: the pattern rules were the largest single block in the rulebook, and the tight gold economy meant strong play cashed cards constantly — which broke patterns up anyway. It was also hard to justify thematically: a civilization does not expand in poker shapes.

The cost is that **meld shape no longer reaches the table**. Under v0.21 a straight of four and a quadruple do exactly the same work — four things done — so the five tiers of meld diagrams describe a distinction with no consequence. If v0.21 playtests as flat, this is the first thing to try restoring, possibly only at the larger melds.

Note that this variant also restores **shift**, and the base game already gives one movement per card played. Running both is untested and probably too much movement.

02

Population limits that grow with your board

DESIGNER'S NOTES — 40 GAMES, 3 PLAYERS, IDENTICAL SEEDS

	BASE (FIXED)	WIDER	THE TABLE ABOVE
units per occupied tile	1.23	1.37	1.30
leader minus last place	15.8	19.5	17.1
leader's units on map	10.9	12.9	11.9
last place's units	5.6	5.6	5.8
rounds · mean score · kills	unchanged within noise		

The whole benefit goes to whoever is already ahead. The leader gains up to two units; last place gains none — reaching Empire is what unlocks the wide limits, so the player who got there first is the only one who banks them. The final

WHY IT WAS REPLACED

It asks every player to remember a number. "How many may I use this round?" is a question the current rule never poses.

It throws a card away against its owner's wishes every round, for every non-winner. Roughly a quarter more happens on the map once that stops.

It produced the worst score floor of any structure measured, at every player count: last place finished on 24.1 / 14.6 / 12.6 at two, three and four players, against 27.8 / 19.0 / 15.1 under the rule that replaced it. Those differences sit outside their confidence intervals; the gap differences between structures do not.

Its headline economy number was inflated. It showed the highest share of cards turned to gold — 47–50% — but part of that was the compulsory docked card. Under the current rule every coin is chosen, and the genuine rate is about a third.

05

Super melds RETIRED

Part of Blink before v0.20, removed to streamline the meld vocabulary.

A super meld is any overlapping combination of melds — one card may belong to several components at once. Each component must be valid on its own, and both the meld limit and the trick score count each **physical card once**.

EXAMPLE

9 Plains, 9 Forest, 10 Forest: the 9 of Forest belongs to both the set 9+9 and the straight 9-10. Three cards, meld score 28.

DESIGNER'S NOTES

Removed on publisher feedback: spotting and verifying overlaps slows the trick for

Once per game, for each terrain, on your map turn, as a free action. No card, no move, no gold. You must hold at least one unit on that terrain. Announce it, work out its strength **S**, resolve it. That terrain is then spent for the rest of the game — four awakenings in total, and no more.

Strength is counted in tiles' worth of people, not in bodies. Divide your units on that terrain by the number below and round down, minimum 1.

	PLAINS	FOREST	MOUNTAIN	OCEAN
population limit	3	2	1	1
units per point of S	3	2	2	1

Three of the four are simply the terrain's own population limit: one point per full tile's worth. Mountain is the exception — two tiles to the point — because mountains are held in numbers rather than in depth

DESIGNER'S NOTES — WHERE THE NUMBERS COME FROM

The powers themselves are **untested**. What has been measured is the thing the scale rests on: how much of each terrain a player actually holds. Sixty three-player games, base rules, peak holdings over the whole game.

	PLAINS	FOREST	MOUNTAIN	OCEAN
units held (peak)	6.3	5.0	4.4	2.2
tiles held	2.4	2.6	4.3	1.7
units per occupied tile	2.6	1.9	1.0	1.0
resulting S	2.1	2.5	2.2	2.2

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